

Mr. ATKINSON'S
CONFESSION
OF HIS
FAITH

Deliver'd at his
ORDINATION,
Janu. the 7th, 17¹²/₁₃.

NOW

*Reprinted by his Order with a short PREFACE to satisfy the
World, That he hath not in the least given in to any New
Notions concerning the Ever Blessed TRINITY in Unity, but
sincerely believes that there is one Onely Living and True
GOD, and that this GOD is FATHER, SON, and HOLY GHOST.*

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THE PREFACE

THAT the World, and particularly my own Congregation, may see I have not alter'd my Sentiments with Reference unto the great Doctrine of the TRINITY, I have thought it proper to Reprint my Confession of Faith; and do make this solemn and publick Declaration, as in the Presence of the All-knowing and Heart-searching GOD, That I don't know I have in any one Point departed from that Faith which I profess'd before many Witnesses, when I receiv'd the Honour from CHRIST to be put into the Ministry. Tho' I must own, That instead of Subscriptions to Words of other Men as fallible as my self, I have always chose to express my Faith either in my own Words, (which all will grant I can with greater Certainty understand) or in the Words which the HOLY GHOST teacheth; and if any desire my Explication of such a Text, as, I and my Father are One: I will freely declare, I believe it takes in a Unity of Nature as well as of Consent. So that the Author of The Noble Stand, might have spar'd that hard Insinuation, as if Ministers were against giving their own Explication of Scripture to those that in a respectful, serious Manner apply'd to them.¹

Our Reasons for not Subscribing the Paper offer'd to us at Salters-Hall, March 3, have been made publick, and I persuade my self, that the unprejudic'd Part of Mankind are convinc'd, our refusing to subscribe at that Time, and in that Manner, was very consistent with our Belief of the Doctrine contain'd in the Article and Catechism (wherein we are so happy as to be acquitted by our Subscribing Brethren) and also very agreeable to the Principles of the REFORMATION, and to our own Principles as Protestant Dissenters, declaring, That the BIBLE is our Religion, and nothing else.

For my own Part, I thought there was the less Reason for Sub-

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scribing, because I never had been suspected of any thing like Arianism; but on the contrary in my Course of Expounding and Preaching have taken all proper Occasions to defend the Doctrine of the TRINITY in the best Manner I could; besides, to subscribe the foremention'd Paper, was out of Place, Time and Order; for we met to agree upon Heads of Advice, and not to adjust any Doctrinal Controversies. And I must own, the Subscription, as then propos'd and insisted upon, in my weak Judgment, had the Appearance of setting up humane Compositions for a Standard of Truth; which I could not come into, least I should seem to charge the BIBLE with Imperfection and Obscurity in Points absolutely necessary to Salvation; tho' I acquit the Subscribers from any such Design; and I am fully satisfy'd we are all of the same Sentiments, That the BIBLE is our only Rule, and that all Men must judge for themselves by this Rule, as well as that the Doctrine of the Glorious TRINITY is most certainly contain'd in the Inspir'd Writings. And I hope, we shall still love as Brethren, and endeavour to keep the Unity of the Spirit in the Bond of Peace.

London, May the 9th. 1719.

THE CONFESSION

OF

FAITH

I BELIEVE in One Onely, the Living and True GOD, who is an Absolute, Independent, Eternal, Unchangeable, and Spiritual BEING, whose Existence is of Himself; Omnipotent, can do all Things that Consist with his Wisdom and other Perfections; *None hath an Arm like GOD, none can thunder with a Voice like Him;* Omniscient, fully comprehends all Things pass'd, present, and to come, and knoweth how to turn every Thing to his own Glory; Every-where present, filleth All, and is in All; Eternal, *the Alpha and Omega, the First and the Last, the Beginning and the End; before the Mountains were brought forth, or ever He had formed the Earth and the World, from Everlasting unto Everlasting He is GOD;* He dwells in that *Light unto which no Man in this State of Imperfection can approach, and live; Whom no Man hath seen, or can see;* but is incomprehensibly Great and Glorious, that *we cannot by Searching find out GOD, we cannot find out the Almighty unto Perfection;* a GOD of boundless Mercy and Compassion, of spotless Purity and Holiness, without Iniquity, Just and Righteous, the same Yesterday, to Day, and for Ever; *without any Variableness or Shadow of Turning,* incapable of receiving any additional Happiness, but is a Self-sufficient and an All-sufficient GOD.

I BELIEVE in the Unity of the GODHEAD; there are Three Persons that are distinguish'd One from the Other in their Ways of subsisting, yet equally enjoying and possessing all the Essential

Attributes and Perfections of the DEITY, as Immensity, Eternity, Infinity, Immutability, Omniscience and Omnipresence, &c. *for there are Three that bear record in Heaven, the Father, the Word, and the Holy Ghost, and these Three are One:* And Persons are commanded to be baptized in the Name of this Sacred TRINITY, whereby it appears, that the very same Worship which is due unto the FATHER, is to be paid to the SON and the SPIRIT, which could not be, if They were not the Most High GOD in the same Essence with the FATHER; and though this is a Mystery above my Comprehension, yet I believe it on the Word of that GOD that cannot lye.

I FARTHER believe, That in the Beginning GOD by his Almighty Power, and the Word gave Being unto all Things, created the Heavens and the Earth, *Things visible and invisible, whether they be Thrones or Dominions, or Principalities, or Powers; all Things were created by Him, and for Him,* Angels in the upper World, and Man in the lower World. But some of the Angels, tho' glorious in their Primitive State, as most nearly resembling the Blessed GOD, in what He had freely bestowed upon them, *kept not their first Estate, but left their own Habitation, and are reserved in everlasting Chains under Darkness unto the Judgment of the Great Day.* And as GOD hath made all Things; so I believe He rules and governs all by his Providence; *He hath set his Throne in the Heavens, and his Kingdom ruleth over all;* yea, He limits and over-rules the sinful Actions of his Creatures to his own Glory; but is no way the Author or Abettor of them.

I BELIEVE, among other Things, GOD created Man in his own Image, after his Likeness, and gave him Dominion over the Fowls of the Air, the Fishes of the Sea, and the Beasts of the Field; and constituted him Lord of this visible Creation, putting all Things under his Feet; and when GOD had thus created Man pure and

holy, and enrich'd his Soul with many excellent Gifts and Endowments, I believe He condescended to Covenant with him, as the natural and federal Head, and Representative of Mankind, and was pleas'd to try his Obedience by this Prohibition, *That he should not eat of the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil*, threatening Death in Case of Disobedience: For it cannot be doubted, but as GOD had made him, so he had an indisputable Right to rule and govern him, and to make what Laws He should think fit and proper for him to observe and obey; and it is not to be question'd, but GOD gave him sufficient Power to do his Duty, or at least, was ready to give him further Aid and Assistance upon his Application to Him for it. But base and ungrateful Man, unmindful of the great Favours he had then lately receiv'd from GOD, and the Obligations under which he was put, to obey, serve, and please GOD, thro' the Subtilty of the Serpent, the Devil, was persuaded to venture on that which GOD had so peremptorily and positively forbidden; by which I verily believe, he ruin'd and involv'd in great Sin and Misery, not only himself, but all that should hereafter come from him by ordinary Generation; *By one Man Sin entred into the World, and Death by Sin; and so Death hath passed upon all, for that all have sinned; and, by the Offence of one, Judgment came upon all Men to Condemnation; that now, what is born of the Flesh is Flesh, and none can bring a clean Thing out of an unclean Thing*: Therefore I must believe, That all mere Men, that spring from *Adam* are naturally corrupt, Sinners from the Womb, and Heirs of Wrath; for by this Apostacy from GOD, Man lost his original Righteousness, the Image of GOD was in a great Measure defac'd in his Soul, and he, who a little before, was the Object of GOD's Love and Delight, afterwards became loathsome and filthy in his Sight; Man having corrupted himself, lost the Favour of GOD, and expos'd himself unto his Wrath in Time and to all Eternity; and in this sinful

and miserable Condition, GOD might have left us, as He did the apostate Angels; but it pleas'd GOD, who hath *Mercy on whom He will have Mercy, and Compassion on whom He will have Compassion*, to pity us in our low Estate, and to give forth a Gracious Promise, *That the Seed of the Woman should break the Serpent's Head*: When we were dropping into Misery, this was the Language of his Grace, *Deliver them from going down to the Pit, I have found a Ransome; I have laid Help on One that is Mighty to save*: When we lay weltring and polluted in our Blood, and none pity'd, or was able to help, then God's own Arm brought *Salvation*, by which *Mercy and Truth are met together, Righteousness and Peace have kissed each other*.

I BELIEVE in the LORD JESUS CHRIST the Second in the most Sacred TRINITY, *who being in the Form of GOD, thought it no robbery, to be equal with GOD, the brightness of his Glory, the express Image of his Person, GOD by Nature, the Father's proper and Natural Son by an Eternal but incomprehensible Generation, who made all things, and without him was not any thing made that was made*, therefore he himself must be uncreated, since it was impossible he should contribute unto the making of himself. Farther, I believe according to the Eternal Compact between the Eternal Father, and this his Son, in the fulness of Time, CHRIST, the Great *Shilo*, the *Messias* spoken of by the Prophets of Old, and prefigur'd by many Types and Shadows under the *Mosaick* dispensation, *took upon him the Seed of Abraham, appeared in the likeness of sinful Flesh, and was made like unto his Brethren in all things, Sin only excepted, that he might be a merciful and faithful High Priest in Things pertaining to GOD, to make reconciliation for the Sins of the People; He was Holy, Harmless, Undefiled, and separate from Sinners, yet a Man of Sorrows, and acquainted with Grief; and being found in Fashion of a Man, He humbled Himself, and became obedient unto Death, even the Death of the Cross; He*

suffered for Sins, *the Just for the Unjust*; was made a Curse for Us, and died in our Room and Place, by which He obtain'd Eternal Redemption for us; so that his Death was a propitiatory Sacrifice, by which GOD the Father was satisfy'd; for God hath set Him forth to be a Propitiation thro' Faith in his Blood, to declare his Righteousness, for the Remission of Sins that are pass'd thro' his Forbearance, that He might be Just, and the Justifier of him that believeth in Jesus.

I BELIEVE, on the third Day He rose again from the Dead, according to the Scriptures, and shewed Himself alive after his Passion by many infallible Proofs, being seen of his Disciples Forty Days, and speaking of the Things appertaining to the Kingdom of God; and after He had given Commandment to them to preach the Gospel, with a Promise to send his Spirit unto them, He ascended up unto the Father's Right Hand, where He maketh Intercession, appearing in the Presence of God for us.

I BELIEVE in the HOLY GHOST the Third in the Sacred TRINITY, who proceeds from the FATHER and the SON, yet God co-equal with them, who applies unto us the Benefits that CHRIST hath purchased by dying, and *works in us to will and to do of his own good Pleasure*, and makes all the Ordinances effectual to the Conviction and Conversion of Sinners, and to the Edification of the Saints in their most Holy Faith; he strives with us, and makes the Elect willing in the Day of his Power, by enlightening their Minds, persuading their Wills, sanctifying their Hearts, purifying their Souls, working Faith in them; and so raiseth them from the Death of Sin, unto the Life of Grace; for since the Fall, it is not in the Power of Man to change his own Heart, or to do any thing that will be acceptable to GOD, without the Help and Assistance of the Blessed Spirit, which God promiseth unto those that sincerely and heartily seek to Him for it.

I BELIEVE that GOD hath had a Church in all Ages of the World, which He hath govern'd, guided and preserv'd by his gracious Providence, in Opposition to all the Designs of Earth and Hell against it; *He hath built his Church on a Rock, and hath promised that the Gates of Hell shall not prevail against it;* this Church (I believe) is not confin'd to any particular Set of Men or Christians, but comprehends all that in all Places and Times of the World, *Worship God in the Spirit, and rejoyce in Christ Jesus, and have no Confidence in the Flesh,* and are united under the LORD JESUS CHRIST, who is the King, and onely Head of the Church; but besides these, who are the Members of the invisible Church, there are many others, that make a credible Profession of Christianity, who are to be accounted Members of the visible Church of CHRIST, and in that respect it may be call'd the *Catholick, or Universal Church,* as taking in all that call and profess themselves Christians; in this He trains up Souls for everlasting Life; for which End and Purpose, He hath appointed his Word, and order'd it to be committed to Writing, which, I believe, is of Divine Authority, and contains all Things necessary unto Salvation; *For the Prophecy came not in old Time by the Will of Man, but holy Men of God spake as they were moved by the Holy Ghost;* these Holy Scriptures, which were *given by Inspiration of God, and are profitable for Doctrine, for Reproof, for Correction and Instruction in Righteousness, that the Man of God may be perfect, throughly furnished unto every good Work,* these Scriptures, I believe, *are able to make us wise unto Salvation, thro' Faith which is in Christ Jesus;* this Sacred Book, I profess to take for my only Rule of Faith, Hope and Life, and do resolve, by the Grace of God, to meditate in it all my Days, to take all my Measures from it, and follow the Directions contain'd in it, and in the whole Course of my Ministry, to keep close to the Mind and Will of God therein reveal'd and declar'd, and do Promise, by the Assistance of the

Holy Spirit, to seal the Truth thereof with my Blood, if ever God in his Providence should call me thereunto.

I BELIEVE that the LORD JESUS CHRIST as the Head and Teacher of his Church, hath appointed a Gospel Ministry, a Set of Men whose Business it is, to Preach the Gospel, and make Offers and Tenders of Grace to lost Sinners, to Woo and Beseech them in CHRIST's Stead to be reconcil'd unto God, to administer the Sacraments, Baptism and the Lord's-Supper, which are the two Seals of the Covenant of Grace, and to exercise Discipline, according unto the Gospel Rule, that Men, after due Examination into the Qualifications, necessary for so great a Work, are, according to CHRIST's Appointment, to be devoted to the Service of the Sanctuary, by *solemn Fasting, Prayer, and Laying on of the Hands of the Presbytery*, and so are to be recommended unto God, and the Word of his Grace, with whom *Christ hath promis'd to be unto the End of the World.*

I FURTHER believe, in order to obtain everlasting Happiness, we must be born again, and be made Partakers of a Divine Nature, and repent of all our Sins, and by a true and lively Faith, that worketh by Love, rely on the LORD JESUS CHRIST for Justification in the Sight of God, and that all the Saints here on Earth, are to keep up External Communion with one another in all the Ordinances of the Gospel, and *as lively Stones are to be built up a spiritual House, an holy Priesthood, to offer up spiritual Sacrifices acceptable unto God by Jesus Christ.*

I BELIEVE, there will be a *Resurrection of the Just and of the Unjust*, that the Bodies of all that sleep in the Dust shall arise, that *what was sown in Weakness, will be rais'd in Power; what was sown in Dishonour, will be rais'd in Glory; what was sown a natural Body, will be*

rais'd a spiritual Body; for the Trumpet will sound, and the Dead will be rais'd incorruptible, and we shall be changed; the Lord Himself will descend with a Shout, with the Voice of the Archangel and the Trump of God, and the Dead in Christ shall rise first; then those that are alive, and remain unto the coming of the Lord Jesus Christ, shall be chang'd and caught up together with them in the Clouds, to meet the Lord in the Air; for I believe, that our Blessed Saviour will come with Power and great Glory (attended with a vast Number of those Morning Stars, that in the Beginning sang together, and those Sons of God that shouted for Joy) to Judge both Quick and Dead.

FINALLY, I BELIEVE all will appear before the Judgment Seat of CHRIST, that *Every one may receive according to what they have done in the Body, whether it be Good or Evil; the Dead small and great shall stand before Him, and the Books will be opened, and all will be Judged out of those Books according unto their Works, and after a strict Enquiry made into what hath been done in this World, CHRIST will proceed to pronounce a solemn and impartial Sentence, which will never be reversed; He will then say unto the Wicked, those that would not hear his Voice, nor hearken to his Calls, Depart from me, ye Cursed, into everlasting Fire, prepared for the Devil and his Angels; it will then be in vain for them to call on the Mountains to fall on them, and to the Hills to hide them from the Face of him that sitteth upon the Throne, and from the Wrath of the Lamb; it will then be to no Purpose, to seek unto him for Mercy, for He will appear unto them as the Lion of the Tribe of Judah, to avenge his Father's Quarrel; then will be the great Day of his Wrath, And who will be able to stand? But Believers (among whom I hope to be found) will have Confidence, and not be ashamed at his Coming; they will then shine forth as the Stars in the Firmament, and lift up their Heads with Joy, because their compleat Redemption*

draweth nigh; for unto them He will pronounce a most grateful and welcome Sentence, *Come, ye Blessed of my Father, inherit the Kingdom prepared for you from the Foundation of the World*: And these two Sentences will be accordingly executed, *the former shall go away into everlasting Punishment, but the Righteous into Life Eternal*.

FINIS.

This edition newly transcribed from the scanned 1719 London printing (Richard Ford, at the Angel in the Poultry; Bodleian copy) and freshly typeset in 2026. The text follows the original wording, spelling, and punctuation; the long f has been modernised and manifest scanning errors silently corrected. Scripture quotations are set in italic and the divine names in small capitals, after the manner of the original.